Niranjan Prasad and Dalvi tried to pacify the corps commander, Dashrath was quietly asked to leave the conference.

The ‘attack’ that was launched the next morning came apart the moment the Chinese came forward to meet the 9 Punjab advance towards Tseng Jong. Kaul, his bravado evaporating with every rifle shot and mortar bomb being fired across the river, beat a hasty exit for Delhi, declaring that ‘the situation had changed’ and he needed to confer with the prime minister. As he watched the retreating back of his corps commander, Dalvi and the commanding officers of the two battalions strung along the riverbed hoped that at least now the reality of the situation on the ground would prevail over political dreams, for it was quite obvious to all present at Nam Ka Chu that the Chinese, by reacting, had ended Kaul’s dream of triumphantly leading 7 Brigade onto the Thagla Ridge.

It took a lot of skill on the part of 9 Punjab’s Major Mahander Singh Chaudhary to pull his men back to the southern side of the Nam Ka Chu. General Kaul’s little thrust across the river was his first real taste of combat where men had died on both sides. However, Kaul’s parting instruction to both Dalvi and Rikh was that 2 Rajput, strung out along the mountain stream, should dig in where they were and protect the bridges, although they had no tactical value and were simple logs used by graziers to cross the river.

If the deployment prior to 10 October 1962 had been tactically poor, after Kaul’s departure it bordered on the absurd. Despite the fact that the Chinese systematically and openly began to prepare for an attack, neither Niranjan Prasad nor John Dalvi took the initiative to redeploy the Rajputs, the Punjabis or the Gorkhas. Once again, every man in the formation knew that the Rajput positions on the Nam Ka Chu were death traps. Yet, for nine days, none of the commanders showed an iota of common sense, preferring instead to complain about their helplessness rather than prepare the troops to fight if attacked.

No surprise then that when the Chinese attack came at dawn on 20 October 1962, the Rajputs fought valiantly but hopelessly on their western flank. Others, including elements of 2 Rajput at Bridge 3, the Assam Rifles, 9 Punjab at Bridge 2, 4 Grenadiers at Bridge 1, 7 Brigade HQ and 1/9 GR at Tsangdhar either fled or disintegrated in the face of the onslaught by Chinese troops supported by artillery.